

What is a Staff+ Engineer?

What the Staff+ role is, expectations and the rewarding and frustrating parts of the job. By former principal engineer Nicky Wrightson.



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JAN 31, 2023 • PAID



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Q: I'm a software engineer and would like to get to the Staff+ level, one day. What do I need to know about this role?

Staff engineer is the software engineering level which follows senior engineer at Big Tech and at companies which want a position for individual contributors (ICs) of greater scope than "senior." Staff+ engineers refer to the positions at or above the Staff level: these are typically Staff, Senior Staff, Principal, Senior Principal, Distinguished or Fellow titles.

We've touched on the Staff+ role in previous articles:

- [Engineering career paths at Big Tech and high-growth startups](#): covering the typical individual contributor career path to Staff engineer.
- [Engineering leadership skill set overlaps](#): similarities and differences between Staff and engineering management.
- [Ways that Staff and Principal engineers get stuck - and how to get unstuck](#): focusing on onboarding, the day-to-day, growing your career, and the organisational factors which lead to people getting stuck.

But we're yet to do a deep dive into the Staff+ engineer role – until now, that is. I cannot think of anyone better to tackle this issue than a long-time Staff+ engineer. So, I turned to [Nicky Wrightson](#), Head of Engineering at [Topi](#), who's been a software engineer for

close to two decades, including working as a Principal Engineer for six years combined at the Financial Times (FT) and Skyscanner.

In this article, Nicky shares her learnings and reflections about the role. We cover:

1. **What is the staff+ role?** Why do companies have this position, how does it differ from a senior engineer role, and what are the different levels?
2. **Expectations.** What changes from being a senior engineer? And what does the day-to-day work look like?
3. **Rewarding parts of this role.** Delivering beyond team boundaries, the people side of it, and wider breadth of involvement.
4. **Frustrations and how to mitigate them.** Failures of influence, varying expectations, imposter syndrome and more.

Staff and above roles

Senior Principal

Principal

Staff



Distinguished

Fellow

Senior Staff

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Staff and above roles. Each company has different expectations of Staff+ levels.

With that, it's over to Nicky:

I've worked as a principal engineer at the Financial Times and Skyscanner and was first promoted to that role at the Financial Times. I had never heard of the Staff+ role while working at investment banks, so never dug into the above-senior engineer roles and what they involved. The Financial Times, despite its print media legacy, has been an early adopter and innovator in its approach to its technology and development processes, including migrating from having architects, to having principal engineers in their place.

My early lack of knowledge about staff+ roles was revealed when I looked for principal roles outside of the FT. I hadn't seen any companies structure them like at the Financial Times and I came across the title of "Staff" for the first time. I had to learn what other companies expected of this level as I couldn't be sure I had the required experience. *To learn more about the structure of this role at the FT, check out the article [Being a Principal Engineer at the Financial Times](#) by Anna Shipman.*

I had assumptions about what the role was. In the end, I landed a senior engineer role with a "principal" title. Once I realised this role and its title were a mismatch, I looked elsewhere. It was at this point that I became invested in understanding Staff+ roles.

Understanding what Staff+ roles involve across the wider industry meant I could articulate what I wanted from the positions I interviewed for. It helped me ask the right questions, to ensure employers understood the role in the same way I did. This new understanding led me to apply to Skyscanner as a principal engineer. [Interesting talks](#) by engineering director [Stuart Davidson](#), who showcased the scale of the problem space at Skyscanner, also helped my choice.

At Skyscanner I found myself jumping into the world of data, with no prior data engineering experience. I was given the option of several areas to join and was excited by the learning opportunity of jumping into a brand new area. Little did I know that when you start processing 2 million events/second, you must discard many of the software engineering paradigms you previously relied on. It was a thrill to take on this unknown part of the stack and get up to speed fast.

1. What is the Staff+ role?

There's a widely adopted two-track system which companies use to scale up their organisation with well-defined responsibilities for each track; one for management and another for individual contributor (IC.) The IC track is seen as the technical path and enables people to continue their growth beyond senior engineer, without getting into management.

I get frustrated at the "individual contributor" title because it indicates your impact is only as an individual and overlooks the aspect of enabling others. In order for IC roles beyond the senior level to be effective, they must include leadership alongside technical expertise and enablement of others.

The purpose of Staff+ roles is to help scale organisations while maintaining quality of execution. For that reason, it becomes more about the enablement of others than pure individual contribution via delivery.

Seasoned technology leader Pat Kua wrote about the [trident model](#) of career progression, consisting of three tracks instead of two. Each track represents where people spend most of their time or energy:

- Management
- Technical leadership
- Individual contribution

Switching to this trident definition of career progression helps structure growth for folks who want to grow technically without management by incorporating technical leadership into the role. Without explicitly calling out this as a leadership role, I have seen ICs that are performing no leadership function rewarded for their individual contribution without rewarding others that are performing critical leadership functions.

Why do companies introduce additional individual contributor levels?

As software development practices have matured, we've moved towards empowering teams to own their domains. This is an evolution of when companies centralised

functions to impose uniformity, like a centralised architecture or infrastructure team. In fast-moving companies, architecture and infrastructure expertise moved into teams as core skill sets and defined as problems for the engineering team.

Empowered teams result in faster iteration cycles. Engineering teams no longer have to wait on a centralised team to make key decisions, meaning empowered and autonomous teams can move faster.

For organisations to scale, we need to enable engineers to concentrate on delivering the right thing. Staff+ engineers help to do this by overseeing the larger technical context and assisting teams to fit best into that larger organisational context.

The problem with empowering autonomous teams is it can omit the benefits of centralised functions, where teams understand well how business domains fit together. centralised teams also means all teams follow consistent approaches. But with them gone, engineers on separate teams now need to own the code they write and also the roadmap, infrastructure, support and code maintenance.

For this organisational evolution to happen, there has been a development of technical approaches. Technology approaches related to cloud computing, distributed systems, observability and automation are all developing quickly across the industry. However, the cognitive load of keeping up with latest practices is a challenge for each team.

How do Staff+ roles differ from a senior engineer role?

Staff+ engineers are all about enabling those around them, particularly other engineers.

They are not just more experienced senior engineers; the Staff+ role is very different from a senior role. It involves switching focus from delivery to enablement; the goal is to indirectly boost engineering output through supportive mechanisms.

Staff+ engineers become force multipliers. You move from being a player to being a coach. You no longer work on one team's objectives, instead you are unblocking them. Supporting teams can mean solving larger issues and helping them to define their technical strategy and execution path, or coaching them through design iterations.

Staff+ engineers proactively identify areas of impact and are skilled at working with a more diverse set of stakeholders to prioritize work.

The different levels of Staff+ roles

Each company has different expectations of the various Staff+ levels. In this section, I'll generalize the most common levels, starting with the Staff level.

Level	Typical scope of the role
Staff	Often embedded in a team, but often in a more complex space with a high degree of inter-team dependencies
Senior Staff	Operates across several teams and will embed where needed
Principal	Operates across many teams, or an entire domain
Senior Principal	Operates across more complex domains, or is brought into business domains to help set direction
Distinguished	Operating across several business domains
Fellow	Working across the entire organisation

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Staff and above roles, and their typical scopes.

A company rarely contains all these levels, or their equivalents. For example, the IC career ladder at the Financial Times had only one additional level, which was principal engineer.

At Skyscanner, levels above senior engineer level were:

- Principal
- Senior principal
- Distinguished engineer
- Fellow

To get a sense of engineering levels at different companies, I suggest browsing the website [Levels.fyi](https://levels.fyi).

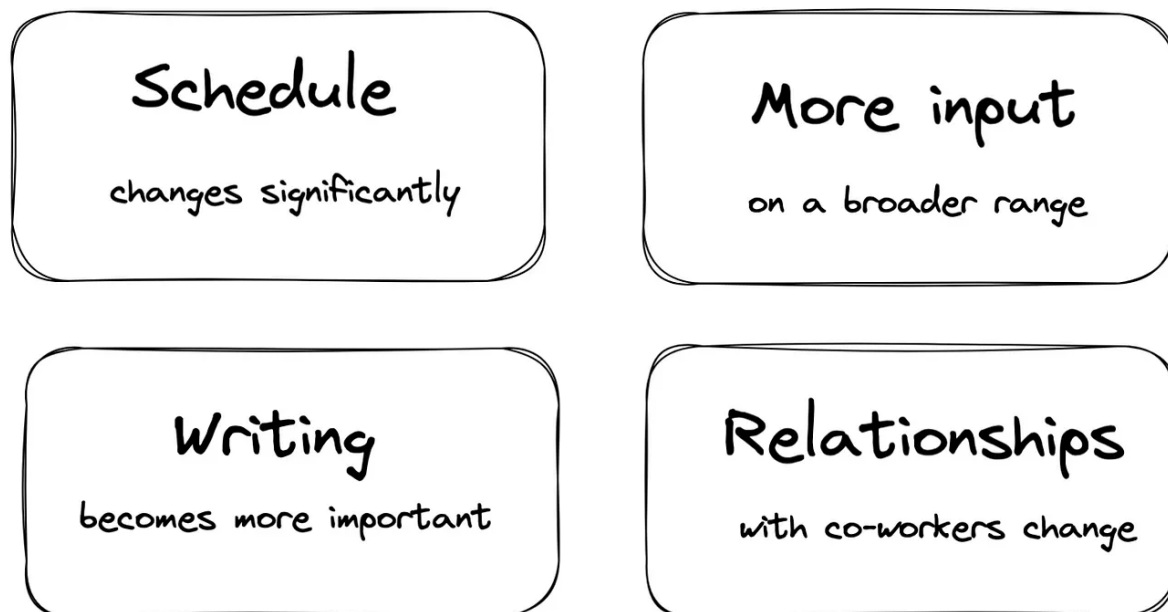
2. Staff+ expectations

I've already stated this is a drastic role change from senior engineer, but what does that mean, exactly? I'll describe what it was like for me, but be aware every Staff+ experience is slightly different.

What changes from your previous IC work?

Basically, you're in a lot more meetings and your calendar looks very different from when you were a senior engineer.

Changes when moving to a Staff+ role



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Some of the things that typically change when moving to a Staff+ role.

Your schedule changes significantly. You have more 1:1s, attend strategy meetings, take part in steering committees, and are invited to team support sessions. While your calendar is no match for how busy the calendars of some managers are, your focus time blocks have vanished. I learned to focus on managing my calendar in order to preserve focus blocks, so I could maintain my hands-on technical knowledge.

Writing becomes more important; not code, but documents. Your primary tool is no longer your integrated development environment (IDE). Instead, you use company communication applications like Slack and other tools like Confluence, Google Docs or Notion. Writing has become a scalable mechanism for helping to influence others and providing visibility into your work.

You have more input on a broader range of things and are recognised as being able to provide value beyond the tech side, and are regarded as a senior technical leader.

At Skyscanner, I was involved in calibration and promotions, a diversity and inclusion action group and I also led a guild. I was a public face for Skyscanner which did have some perks, such as occasionally taking prospective candidates for lunch. I also often did public speaking and wrote articles to help strengthen Skyscanner's technical brand.

In most companies, the beauty of the Staff+ role is how you can get involved wherever you think will have the most impact.

Your relationships with your co-workers change. You're no longer working shoulder-to-shoulder on issues and may only see colleagues in occasional meetings, meaning the bonds you share may weaken. This can lead to an "us and you" mindset, a silo mentality which can harden because your co-workers' expectations of you have changed; where you used to collaborate on issues, you're now expected to help unblock issues, or solve external contributing factors for them.

So, you find yourself spending a lot more time giving guidance. Product will want your technical input on the roadmap and engineering leaders want your input on work they're leading. You'll be pulled into quarterly planning meetings and asked about reorganisation options.

What does the day-to-day look like?

Generally, my working week as a Staff+ tended to be made up of categories:

Mentoring & coaching

I would plan for 3 to 4 individual mentoring slots a week. Two to three were for me to mentor others, and one was for me to be mentored. I broadcasted my availability for mentoring, which was one of the most rewarding and educational parts of this role for me. I was also proactive in seeking mentors to build relationships with and to extend my understanding of the wider business.

There was also team mentoring and coaching in various guises. I attended some team ceremonies, such as planning or standups, or whenever I was needed most. I also provided feedback on designs or proposals. I got involved in incident reviews and took interest in the write-ups, as well as helping to facilitate learning sessions after an outage. Here, I was very much in a coaching role and sometimes facilitated sessions in areas which I had no expertise in. But with the right questions, we dug into all the contributing factors to an incident.

Strategy and planning

As a generalist on technical input, my value came from problem spotting and making early discoveries in a new problem space. That's not to say I did not provide value for existing problem areas, but I saw the team as the experts rather than myself. So, I tended to highlight more opaque and unaccounted-for problems.

There's a large degree of discovery and strategy work in helping a team prioritise and plan, which I spearheaded, ideally alongside a product manager. This involved talking to a lot of people, writing proof of concepts and other documents, then distilling it all at a high-level for teams to own.

The strategy needed to be high-level enough to ensure that teams had enough autonomy to design the solution themselves. However, the strategy still needs sufficient definition to not be overwhelmingly ambiguous. My role was to bring a team into the problem space and hand it over to them.

I also got to spend a significant amount of time on planning for business areas. They asked for my input about the impact of their changes on my area, or integrations and feasibility assessments. Many companies used the OKR framework and during the run-up to publishing key results, I spent the most time in this area.

Recruitment and retention

The recruitment side of things was not my favorite. Still, we needed to continue to improve recruitment, especially around inclusivity, and also increasing the quality of the signals in this process. Being heavily involved was the only way I could improve things.

This included doing interviews, influencing the process design, formats, approaches and reaching out to folks who could be great additions to the team. It usually took up a couple of hours a week, but could sometimes balloon to around 50% of my workload, sometimes spilling over to outside of work hours, too, when running meetups or other events for encouraging potential candidates to apply.

Worker retention is a very broad bucket. My involvement varied, including calibration meetings and reviewing promotion packets. I was often asked to talk with engineers we thought were not doing great or not enjoying their roles, to see what opportunities I could find for them. I'm vocal about providing the right incentives for the right behaviors and this took up a lot of my time during promotion and review periods.

3. Rewarding parts of the job

The Staff+ role was difficult but also rewarding. This is what I got out of the role.

Delivering beyond team boundaries

In the Staff+ role, you deliver more via influencing and supporting others. One of my motivations has always been shipping something useful which I'm proud of. When I moved into the Staff+, I stepped away from delivering direct outputs. What did not change is that I still shipped things. However, I delivered much more through influencing and supporting others.

Being Staff+ scaled my opportunity for delivery and seeing people get things done whom I had helped, fuelled my motivation. The first time I experienced this was when I took over a multi-year project at the FT to re-imagine a unified content platform. We had 5 teams spread across 3 countries, all delivering towards the same goal, with me conducting the technical output. This project was bigger than anything I could have achieved with a single team. We were ripping out core parts out of the platform powering the FT, and replacing them seamlessly – all because we were aligned.

I started looking for solutions beyond team boundaries. Stepping outside of the team, I found myself looking at alternative and more satisfying solutions. Rather than attempting to code my way around external blockers, I tried to get external teams to work with me from within the organisation, or elicited help from folks at other companies.

An example of working around external blockers was migrating to Kubernetes from our home-grown container orchestration. During this process, our pods repeatedly lost communication with the controller for seemingly no reason. It was late 2017, when Kubernetes was starting its meteoric rise in adoption. We could not find anything online to help us resolve the problem and considered writing code to force re-communication between the pod and controller. This felt hacky to me, because communication with the controller is core functionality I would expect from Kubernetes.

I knew Monzo was heavily invested in Kubernetes. So, I reached out to people there asking for help. They told us straight away what the problem was and pointed us to a pull request (PR) with the fix. An engineer at Monzo agreed to meet me for a coffee. I did feel sorry for him as I took several senior engineers along who all had questions. Afterwards, we sent brownies as a 'thank you' for their patience and help.

The people aspect

The Staff+ role is much more about people. I get a warm feeling when I see my actions help someone; be it mentoring an engineer, or providing opportunities.

As a Staff engineer, I tend to have more context than most engineers. From speaking to a wide variety of people, I get to hear about problem spaces early. Often, I spot incidents where people are being hampered and are working around an issue, such as

inconsistencies in our data, or the release process being burdensome for front-end development. I make suggestions to engineers on how they can get involved, or make some introductions to get them in the right room.

I have made suggestions, such as a large-scale data migration being led by a senior engineer instead of myself, with me acting in a supporting role. In this case, it gave that senior engineer so much more room for growth.

Seeing engineers grow thanks to you is the most satisfying aspect of the Staff+ role. Some of my favorite moments are when I observe people or teams whom I've helped, take ownership of complex problem areas that used to be too large. I supported and mentored a mid-level engineer through their first design proposal and it made me feel better to see them nailing answers to questions from a much more senior colleague, something that wouldn't have happened had I presented myself.

My aim is to pay forward my experience and also the amazing support and sponsorship I've received. The Staff+ role is about the people around you; you are solving larger problems that you can no longer code your own way out of. You need to influence others to deliver better, rather than directly deliver by yourself. When this works, it is incredibly rewarding.

Wider breadth of involvement

As a Staff+ engineer, I had more autonomy to choose how to direct my impact; therefore, I could get involved with several things simultaneously.

At Skyscanner, I was working with the teams in my tribe, which is a collection of squads and chapters, as per the [Spotify tribe engineering model](#). I was also collaborating with recruitment to help us expand our hiring funnel and make it more diverse, working with the production platform on observability, working with the people team around supporting female engineers, leading the data architecture guild, and also mentoring. I influenced areas like recruitment or leveling decisions, to which senior engineers have less access.

I was invited to promotions boards and calibration meetings at which I supplied evidence of good work by others. On promotion boards, I reviewed appraisals.

The parts of the business I got involved with varied and I was regularly pulled into design discussions about different business areas. Some common reasons why Staff+ engineers are pulled into an initiative or design discussion:

1. How would this change affect my area?
2. What asks does the team have for work from the area I own?
3. How can they integrate with some areas that I am working in?

When I was working in data at Skyscanner, the most common ask was to do with data sets for building a new product. Which was the right dataset to use? Was a new dataset needed? Where would the data come from? What would the dataset look like? Then, was the data good enough to use for the requirements of the product? Was the data set complete enough, resilient enough, and did it arrive quickly enough to satisfy requirements?

I loved jumping around like this, as it gave me so much more context for my day-to-day. At the same time, I was learning and building up relationships within the business.

4. Frustrations and how to mitigate them

There isn't a cookie-cutter template for Staff+ roles, which can lead to frustrations and apathy. Here's some common frustrations I had and how I tried to mitigate.

Frustrations in a Staff+ role

Influencing others

Influencing can be unexpectedly challenging

Definition of 'success'

Results are not immediate, measuring is harder

A vague role

Often having competing expectations from others

Getting 'stuck'

Because of the broad scope & ambiguity

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Common frustrations that come with Staff+ roles.

Influencing others

Nearly every aspect of being a Staff+ engineer involves influence; it's your tool for delivery. Working with autonomous teams, the teams own delivery, which means input from Staff+ engineers should influence their decision-making process.

As a Staff+ engineer, you should not direct teams or people on what to do. You should use your influence to help them come to decisions which they own.

In Staff+ roles, you need to influence up, down and sideways. I identified work needed on data quality at Skyscanner, but to get this work prioritised I needed to convince leadership there was a problem with potentially massive impact, and also convince my peers of this so they could champion this work and smooth over integration points. Finally, I influenced the team on the direction of travel when they took ownership of the problem space.

Not everyone is a natural influencer, and it's rarely something engineers are taught. At some point, you will inevitably struggle to influence something important and being unable to get your way when you think your approach is the best for the organisation, will always feel frustrating.

As a Staff+ engineer, you must identify and flag problems early. However, spotting problems and suggesting solutions is only useful if you can first convince others there is an impactful problem worth solving. You then need to convince teams to prioritize that task against their current commitments.

To prioritize important work which you've identified, you could collaborate with Product to incorporate your initiatives into the team's roadmap. However, you might stumble upon a wide-reaching problem that belongs higher up in the planning process, so Staff+ engineers often have to influence up to the C-suite level to get work prioritised.

Staff+ roles involve influencing team-level decisions on a daily basis; you can't just lock yourself away and code your way out of problems like a senior engineer. You are most likely less hands-on, as you have moved away from shipping product features. Now, you work with others to aid them in defining the right way to deliver their product.

I have never managed to eliminate the frustration of struggling to influence people. I now have my own rubric for turning frustration into constructive learning. I've reflected on the causes of failures and observe there are two categories:

1. *My ability to influence failed.* I look at ways in which I could have influenced more effectively. Was I influencing the person or team with decision-making power? Was my argument structured and delivered well? Was I appealing to the right incentives? What could I have done better, and how will I change my approach next time?
2. *The team or person I was trying to influence was right, and I was wrong.* Accepting I was just plain wrong was not something I adapted to quickly. There are rarely right or wrong ways to tackle engineering problems. Instead, there are better or worse approaches. If you want to optimize a solution for speed over the readability of the code, then the "better" code will look very different. So, when I got

something “wrong” as a Staff+, I dug deeper into the context of the problem space and looked at what the other solutions optimised for.

Do not use your positional authority to “pull rank” during the decision making process. Doing this erodes trust and influence even if you are right, as Jeffery Sherman writes in the article, [Dangers of pulling rank as a staff engineer](#).

Read more about influencing in the issue on [Internal politics for software engineers and managers: Part 1](#) and [Part 2](#).

The definition of ‘success’

You rarely see immediate results from your efforts. This is especially true when you are enabling others to deliver more effectively. Coaching and mentoring others can be “invisible” work and the same is true for influencing technical choices and the direction of projects.

I remember being excited when an engineer proposed an approach I had been championing. However, they didn’t credit me. But this is normal; we don’t remember all the sources that go into the amalgamation that is our learning. However, it can be frustrating, although it would be in bad taste to jump up and down saying “that’s my approach!” about their proposal. In a way, it was an indicator of my success that they adopted something I was trying to influence.

I counteract the lack of credit in a couple of ways. I frequently write down my thoughts on topics and distribute them for reference and I also share ‘invisible successes’ with my manager.

Measuring success can end up being more subjective than we’d normally like. In a role based on influence, how do you measure the success in a data-driven manner? After all, you can no longer measure success by deliverables.

I do not have the perfect answer for how to ensure you get the right recognition when you help others become successful, as a Staff+. My approach is to track what I’m doing and give feedback to my manager about my perceived impact. I also set clear objectives and success criteria with my manager and regularly reflect on my progress.

The vagueness of the role

Staff+ roles are rarely well understood by everyone. Career frameworks are intentionally vague for these roles, in order to create flexibility. Different Staff+ engineers have different areas of focus and ways of working. There's very little uniformity in interactions with others.

This vagueness of Staff+ roles leads to everyone having different – and sometimes competing – expectations of you. I have found it is important to state my expectations of ways of working when I start collaborating with a new stakeholder or team. Alternatively, we do a collective exercise defining roles and responsibilities when a new team or initiative is spun up.

There's also the common expectation of Staff+ people that they have all the answers and can be parachuted in anywhere to solve hard problems straight away. I've often been asked to help in areas about which I had no experience, and initially I compared myself to others doing the job with more experience. This led to the anxiety that's part of imposter syndrome. I have learnt to be patient with myself when getting to grips with new stuff. I'm now also clear with others about my strengths and what I need to get up to speed on, and gaining agreement on how I can help.

From the start, I aim to state upfront what I am going to deliver to the people I work with, so they have a feel for the expectations. I also point out where expectations don't match. For example, I did not facilitate a design review on a project I was leading and an engineering manager asked me why I'd let a colleague lead the review. Was it not a Staff+ engineer's responsibility to lead design reviews, thought this manager. I took the opportunity to evangelize the supportive and mentoring nature of my role, instead of realigning with this manager's expectations of my role.

Easy to get “stuck”

It's easy to get “stuck” in the Staff+ role because of its broad scope, ambiguity and the mixed expectations.

As a Staff+ engineer, it was my emotions which alerted me when I was getting stuck, more than any form of data. When I felt frustrated that things I worked on were not

being prioritised, it was a sign that I was getting stuck. It was the same when I was spending more time talking about why I couldn't get something done, rather than getting on with things. When I noticed that I felt I had let down people whom I made commitments to, then I was "stuck."

I've got "stuck" in numerous ways over the years. Common situations included:

- **Solving it all at once.** I spent time on many problems while not moving any of them forward in a valuable manner, due to constantly jumping from one issue to the other. Having too many problems meant having too little focus time for each one.
- **Saying "yes" too much.** When I said "yes" to everything, it resulted in an ever-growing to-do list and stress. When this led to feeling like I had let down people, it had a measurable effect on my mental health and amplified imposter syndrome.
- **Inconsistent expectations.** When there was a difference between my expectations and my manager's, it either led to me working towards the wrong goals, or my manager being disappointed that I hadn't fulfilled expectations.

Lean on your manager to help you get unstuck. Your manager is key to this and it was through my managers that I got myself unstuck in the above cases.

Today, I always seek new tips and tricks from people around me who seem to get a lot done. I look for tips on prioritization, delegation and calendar management. I also keep a Trello board of my work. I use this board as a basis for updates for my manager, so they have visibility into my work. I am normally quite open about the pitfalls I tend to fall into, and trust my manager to help me not get stuck in the first place.

I sidestepped a lot of problems around getting "stuck" by building good relationships with managers. I provided my manager with a constant stream of updates on blockers and impacts.

One thing that has not become easier to deal with, is disagreements with managers about expectations. Solving this is always situation-dependent, and sometimes, getting on the same page can be as simple as discussing points of view and agreeing on new expectations.

For more advice on getting unstuck, see the article [Ways Staff and Principal engineers get stuck \(and how to get unstuck\)](#).

Influencing organisational change

Staff+ roles rarely come with organisational influence and the authority to make organisational changes sits with managers. While this separation makes sense, as a Staff+ engineer who has previously managed teams, I tend to spot opportunities where organisational reorganisation could improve the technology architecture.

So, how can you bring your suggestions for organisational structure change to the table?

organisational change is infrequent and scary in most organisations for good reason. Changes can be similar to large changes to monolithic applications. However, when they're done frequently as small reorgs, they become a useful tool for evolving the company.

When I worked at the Financial Times, there was a culture of organisational change. We had long-lived group structures, but teams regularly disbanded and formed to deliver specific projects. I became used to small "reorganisations" which helped us execute better.

If you are a Staff+ engineer interested in team structures, I encourage you to read and re-read the [Team Topologies](#) book. This book does a great job of showcasing how different organisation structures help an organisation succeed. Once you understand how team structures play a big part in execution, it can feel frustrating when you cannot influence teams to reorganise for the better.

This frustration of being unable to influence organisational change can be the hardest to counteract. I have never stopped trying, though. I approach influencing organisational change in the same manner that I put cases for architectural or tech changes:

- What is the problem to solve?

- Propose alternatives and their benefits.

When suggesting organisational changes, expect your influence to be weaker than if you suggest technical changes. This is because Staff+ engineers tend to have more technological influence than organisational.

However, just because your org influence is weaker than your technical influence, it doesn't mean you can't be hugely impactful. I have been involved in many re-orgs, providing advice on how to best augment the team structure to deliver and provide tangible value. Due to my understanding of the link between systems, the upcoming roadmap and the technical debt of a product area, I can suggest successful team structures.

Summary

It was never my ambition to become a Staff+ engineer. But my enjoyment of delivering stuff and desire to take on more and bigger responsibilities, eventually led me to this role.

I have gone into detail about this role's frustrations, but the truth is that by the time I encountered these frustrations, the genie was out of the bottle; I enjoyed the new and bigger challenges that came with a Staff+ role such as principal engineer, and I experienced the positive impact of this position. The scale of this impact was unlike any I'd experienced before and got me hooked enough to find ways through the frustrations and to use these challenges to grow.

Takeaways

This is Gergely. Thank you, Nicky, for sharing your learnings! Follow Nicky [on Twitter](#) and [on LinkedIn](#) to keep up with her thoughts.

Staff+ roles are important for senior engineers to understand, in order to decide if this is a career path for them. Understanding Staff+ roles is also important for managers, to decide when and if their organization needs them, and how to support and get the most out of Staff+ engineers.

Some highlights for me from Nicky's story and learnings are:

"Staff+ engineer" means very different things at different companies. Nicky got burnt when taking a principal engineer job after leaving The Financial Times, as that role was akin to a senior engineer role, and not what she was looking for. In some ways, it's to be expected that beyond the senior engineer levels, roles become a lot more bespoke for each organization.

If you're looking for Staff+ roles, learn from Nicky's story and clarify what the role is about. And as a manager, aim to specify what you expect from staff and principal engineers; capture this both internally and in job descriptions, as we cover in the article [Hiring software engineers](#).

Staff+ engineers frequently work across teams. With the caveat that the Staff+ role can vary at different businesses and tech companies, working across teams brings some common challenges for this role.

Staff+ engineers need to be good at building relationships with colleagues in different teams and they also need to put down roots in their "main" team, if there is one. At the same time, they'll have far more meetings than most engineers, all while being expected to still be more hands-on than most engineering managers.

Writing becomes more important as a Staff+ engineer. Nicky mentioned writing is the salable mechanism for Staff+ engineers to influence others, and I couldn't agree more. For more advice on improving your writing, see the article [Becoming a better writer](#).

Staff+ roles come with plenty of frustrations. Staff+ is a leadership position on the individual contributor track. As such, it brings challenges like those of the engineering manager role. For example, expectations are not always clear. Even worse, Staff+ engineers have expectations from their software engineer peers, different ones from engineering managers, and yet other distinct expectations from other stakeholders, like product managers or business folks.

A Staff+ role tends to come with less authority than a manager role, which can make it more challenging to influence others. Thanks to all this ambiguity and expectation, it

can be easy to get "stuck," as Nicky discusses in this article, and as I've done in the issue [Ways Staff and Principal engineers get stuck](#).

The Staff+ role is distinct from a senior engineer role. Nicky does a great job of sharing lots of stories and learnings about why these differences exist. Being a great senior engineer and being a great Staff+ engineer involves different skills, and the Staff+ role is rarely just a continuation of the senior engineer role.

If you're hoping to one day get to Staff+, I hope you find this overview useful. If you manage Staff+ engineers, hopefully, this article helps build even more empathy, although nothing beats talking with your engineers directly about their own challenges.

If you're already in a Staff+ role, please share your own interpretation of it:

Further reading

Here are resources Nicky recommends for reading if you'd like to learn more about staff+ positions.

Articles:

- [Being a principal engineer at the Financial Times](#) by Anna Shipman
- [Pyramid Principle](#), a methodology for structured communication

Books:

- [Team Topologies](#) by Manuel Pais and Matthew Skelton
- [Elements of Influence](#) by Terry R. Bacon
- [The Staff Engineer's Path](#) by Tanya O'Reilly. We also [covered an excerpt from this book](#).
- [Staff Engineer: Leadership beyond the management track](#) by Will Larson



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Aaron Erickson · Writes 2024 · Jan 31 · ❤️ Liked by Gergely Orosz

Great write up.

One thing I've found is that the road is a lot easier if you are promoted into Staff+ over hired into it, as in the former case, you will typically have a lot of the organizational context and relationships to help you be successful.

The higher up that ladder you go, the more it seems to matter. Outside of maybe hiring someone very famous, it's hard to see how anyone above Senior Principal could do the job coming in from the outside.

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